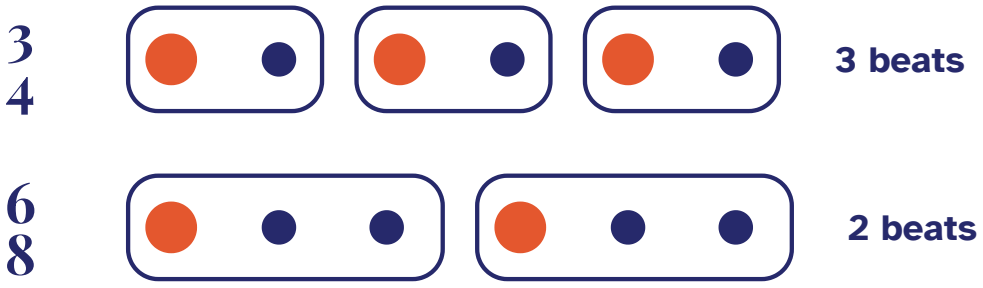
PART II · TIME · 5

Compound and irregular time

Compound time is a skipping rope: each dotted beat splits into **three**. Irregular time keeps you guessing, with **five or seven** counts in uneven groups. (9/4, 12/4 and /16 signatures are rare.)

THE SECRET

Dotted beats split in three: 6/8 is two big beats.



Same six quavers, new groups

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

Quick test: a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

Compound time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
6/8	2 dotted crotchets	Level 1
9/8	3 dotted crotchets	Level 3
12/8	4 dotted crotchets	Level 3
6/4	2 dotted minims	Level 4

Counting 6/8



Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

Irregular time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
5/4	5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	Level 5
7/4	7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4	*Extra*
5/8	5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	*Extra*
7/8	7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2	*Extra*

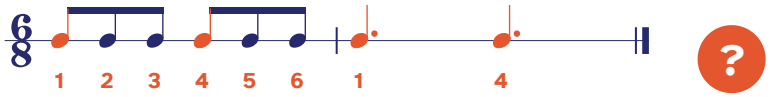
UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.



EXAMPLE 1

How many beats in a bar of 6/8?



1. **Slowly, count all six quavers.**
2. **Which two counts** feel strong? (the red notes)
3. **Faster, count only the strong ones.** How many?

6/8 has **two beats** in a bar (1 and 4), each split into three quavers.

GAME

Two beats or three?

1	2	3	4
6/8	3/4	9/8	2/4

How many beats in a bar, and does each beat split in two or in three?

Answer: 1 two, in threes · 2 three, in twos · 3 three, in threes · 4 two, in twos.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

6/8

Sway left, sway right.

Say “1 2 3, 4 5 6” and sway once on 1 and once on 4. That is 6/8: six quavers, two big beats.

HOW TO

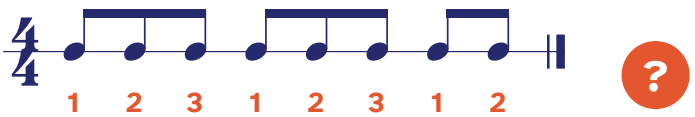
Feel compound time

1. **Say “pine-ap-ple”** on every beat and step only on “pine”.
2. **Clap the three syllables** while you step.

PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Is this still 4/4?



1. **Count eight quavers** in the bar.
2. **Group them 3 + 3 + 2:** where do the accents fall?
3. **Keep your foot on the beat.** How many foot taps?

Accents on 1, 4 and 7, but four foot taps: the bar is still **4/4**, only the accents are uneven.

EXAMPLE 3

How many beats in 9/8?
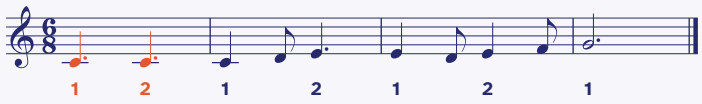


1. **The top number, 9:** does it divide by 3?
2. **How many groups of three** fit in 9?
3. **What is each beat**, in quavers?

9 ÷ 3 = **three beats**, each a dotted crotchet: “1 2 3, 4 5 6, 7 8 9”.

YOU KNOW THIS

Row, Row, Row Your Boat



Two big beats in every bar, each a **dotted crotchet**: “Row, row”. Each big beat is worth three quavers: “row your” is long-short, a crotchet and a quaver, filling one big beat. That is 6/8.

Try it. Sway twice per bar while you sing it.

THINK OF IT Like a skipping rope: two big swings, each with three little steps inside.

TRAP

- × Counting 6/8 as six slow beats at speed: feel two big ones.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: the same six quavers, grouped differently.

SEE ALSO

Time signatures p. 55 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 61

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels 1–4 · Compound time · Online: Rhythm clock